

1 Conversational skills

- Lead-in** Some business practices may differ from country to country. Here are some questions to research before you meet new business contacts:
- 1 In conversations, is it usual for the person who isn't speaking to remain silent or to comment on the conversation?
 - 2 When you meet someone when networking, is it usual to exchange business cards and to send an email after the event?
 - 3 What greetings are most appropriate (e.g. shaking hands, bowing)?

Introductions

Introducing yourself	Responding to an introduction
Hi/Hello, my name's Toby. Can I introduce myself? I'm Chris.	It's a pleasure to meet you. Good to meet you.

Participating in a conversation

	Formal	Informal
Starting or joining a conversation	What do you think of the conference? Do you mind if I join you? Do you have a moment to discuss your company? Would it be possible to talk about your training programme?	Hi, are you enjoying the conference? Is it OK if I join you? Do you have time for a quick chat? Is now a good time to talk about your training programme?
Closing	I really appreciate your time. Thank you. Would it be possible to contact you to discuss this further? Thank you so much, that was very informative. Can I give you my business card? May I have your business card?	Thanks for taking the time to talk to me. Can I get in touch next week to talk about this in more detail? It was great speaking to you. Here's my card. Do you have a business card?

Showing interest

There are different strategies for showing interest during a conversation. It is polite to keep your attention focused on the speaker and to use body language as well as words to show that you are paying attention (e.g. looking at the person speaking, nodding, smiling).

Commenting	Really? That's interesting! Right. OK. I see. Ah! Uh-huh.
Asking questions	Can you tell me more about the recruitment process? Who is the best person to contact about applications?
Clarifying	Did you say that you employ 3,000 people worldwide? So is it better to contact you by phone or email?
Showing your research	I noticed on your website that you employ interns. Your company brochure was very informative.
Repeating back	So you have a graduate training programme. It's interesting to hear that you have apprenticeships in computing.

2 Telephone skills

- Lead-in** Some business practices may differ from country to country. Here are some questions to research before you make telephone calls:
- 1 Are calls usually short and to the point or is some small talk expected?
 - 2 How quickly are phone messages returned?
 - 3 When you take or leave a message, what key information would you expect to exchange?
 - 4 How are numbers grouped when saying a telephone number?
 - 5 What details would be expected when recording a message on the telephone?
 - 6 Is it acceptable to cut a conversation short when you are busy or will the person you are speaking to be offended?

Making contact

	Formal/Semi-formal	Less formal
Starting a call	Hello, my name is Claudia Peck from Tevo Industries. Can I speak to the Sales Director, please? Good morning, my name is Cara Madaki. We met at the computer security seminar last week.	Hi, Fabio. It's Susan here. This is Monika from accounts.
Receptionist	Cranfield Computing, how can I help? Could you hold the line, please? I'm putting you through now.	Hi, Kendle Electronics. One moment. I'll put you through now.
Receiving a call	Hello, Tang Ka-yee speaking. You're through to the Customer Services Manager.	Hi, James Glover. Speaking.
Stating the reason for your call	Would it be possible to arrange a meeting to present our new product range? I have a quick query about your latest expenses claim. You suggested that I call to discuss my internship application. Hi Lars, this is Charlotte. I received your message about the brochures.	It's about the presentation. I'm calling with a quick question. You said I should call to discuss the internship. Hi, Gina. I'm calling about your voicemail message. Hi, I got your message.

Ending the call

Cutting short a call	Can I call you back? I'm in the middle of something. I'll take your details and call you back. Can I call you later? I'll get back to you later today.
Confirming action	So, I'll see you on Thursday at 3 p.m. I'll call you back as soon as I have the figures. I'll call tomorrow to confirm details.
Ending the call	Thanks for calling, bye. Thank you for your help. It was nice speaking to you, bye.

Leaving a message

Leaving a message	Can I leave a message, please? Could you tell Lisa that Judith called about the catering order?
Checking understanding	Could you read that back, please? Would you like me to repeat the number?
Requesting action	Do you know when she will be back? Can you ask him to call me back this afternoon? Could you tell Tomas that it's urgent, please? Is there anyone else who could help?

Taking a message

Taking a message	Sorry, Louis isn't in the office today. Can I take a message? Katrin isn't here at the moment. Would you like to leave a message?
Checking understanding	So that's 738 562 991? Can I read that back? Did you say fifteen or fifty?
Confirming action	I'll give him your message as soon as he returns. She won't be back in the office until Monday. Would you like to speak to someone else about this?

Voicemail messages

Identifying yourself	Hi, this is Lars Jansen from Lumiglow.
Giving a reason for your call	I'm calling about your order for the new brochures.
Giving key information	There is a problem with the delivery date. Could you call me back on 0998 639 232? I'll be in the office until 6 p.m. Could you contact me by tomorrow morning, please?
Repeating or spelling information	That's oh_double nine_eight, six_three_nine, two_three_two. That's spelt L_U_M_I_G_L_O_W.

3 Meeting skills

Lead-in

- Some business practices may differ from country to country. Here are some questions to research before you prepare for a meeting:
- 1 Is the meeting formal or informal? What is the aim?
 - 2 Are there likely to be different opinions? What are the main arguments for and against the topic being discussed?
 - 3 What outcome do you want from the meeting? How will you record action points?

Introductions and opening

Welcoming people	Thank you all for coming today.
Introducing participants	I think we all know each other, don't we? Could we all say our name and role?
Clarifying aims	The aim of this meeting is to agree the new budget. You'll see from the agenda that we are here to discuss three main points. We need to agree on who is working on each project.
Opening a meeting	OK, let's begin by looking at the first point on the agenda. Shall we start by discussing the schedule?

Participating

Asking for opinions	What are your thoughts on this? What do you think, Natalia? Any ideas?
Giving an opinion	In my opinion, we should look for a new supplier. I think this would help our clients.
Agreeing/Disagreeing	That's a good point. I agree with Jean Luc. That's a really good idea. That would work. I can see your point but I can't agree. I'm afraid I don't agree.
Clarifying	What I meant to say was (the figures aren't reliable). To put it another way (we need to spend less on marketing). Can I check what you mean by (cost cutting)?

Updates and action

Asking for an update	How are we doing with the new factory plans? Can you give me a quick update on your current projects? Have you updated the team on the new schedule? Where are we with the new price list? What's happening with the new computer software? Can you bring me up to speed on the Ferguson contract?
Giving an update	
Talking about past action Talking about current action Talking about planned action	I completed the sales figures on Monday. The delivery was late so we missed the deadline. The design is in progress at the moment. I'm currently finalising the report I'm expecting the order confirmation this afternoon. We'll sign the contract tomorrow.
Giving an update on problems and solutions	The only problem is the currency rates, which might affect the budget. There was a problem with the menu, but we spoke to the caterers and found a solution. We're working on it at the moment and should have a solution by the end of the day.
Action points	Can you call the supplier by the end of today and change the quantity? We need a response by the end of this week. Get back to me on Thursday with an update, please. Justin will speak to sales and Monika can talk to the client. Does everyone know what they need to do?

Talking about priorities

Important	It is of the utmost importance that we come to a decision. This should be our number one priority. This issue is high priority. This is extremely important. We really need to decide on the deadline. The main issue is how much this will cost.
Less important	This is a low priority for our department. It's quite important but we don't need an immediate decision. It's not urgent. This isn't currently a priority. That isn't so important for us. We'd prefer to focus on the budget.
Postponing	We can put off the decision until we have more facts. Can we delay the deadline until next week? Let's explore some solutions and then come to a decision. We can talk about this later.

Reaching agreement

- When discussing problems and issues, consider the following:
- 1 Understand and communicate the main priority of the discussion.
 - 2 Talk about facts and issues rather than personal comments. Try to use *we* statements rather than *you* statements.
 - 3 If it is not possible to come to agreement, arrange another discussion at a later date.

Agreeing	Yes, I agree with Anton. I see what you mean. I completely agree. Exactly!
Disagreeing	I'm afraid I disagree. Sorry, I don't agree. I'm not sure I agree with that.
Agreement not reached	We may have to agree to disagree. I don't think we can reach agreement today but we'll discuss this again later.
Making suggestions / Stating preferences	I think we should (have an international team). How about (changing the logo)? Why don't we (ask our customers)? We could (hire some short-term staff for the project). Have you considered (replacing the old equipment)?
Reacting to suggestions	That's a good point. That's a good idea. That could work. I think you're right. It's a nice idea, but I don't think it will work.

Resolving conflict

Explaining problems	The main problem is that (the supplier can't deliver the order). The issue is that (we don't have enough staff). The thing is that (the equipment is broken) and so (we won't be able to finish the task).
Outlining solutions	It might be a good idea to have weekly meetings. There are two possible solutions. What do you suggest? Let's try to find a solution together. What would you like to happen?
Inviting consensus	Can we come to an agreement? Would that work? Are we all agreed? Can we all agree on that?

Closing a meeting

Thank you for coming today. It was a very useful meeting. We'll meet again next week to discuss next steps.

4 Presentation skills

Lead-in

- Some business practices may differ from country to country. Here are some questions to research before you prepare presentations for different audiences:
- 1 How formal or informal is the presentation?
 - 2 Are you presenting as an individual or as a group? If presenting as a group, how have tasks been allocated? Is everyone clear what they need to do?
 - 3 How much detail do you need? What does your audience already know about the topic?
 - 4 What information is better spoken and what information would be clearer presented as slides or pictures?

Presenting ideas (informal presentation)

Generating ideas	Shall we brainstorm some ideas? I want to hear your ideas about how to improve customer service. What are your thoughts on the new marketing campaign?
Discussing ideas	What we need to do is identify our key market. Basically, sales and marketing should share an office. Why don't we work in small groups?
Presenting ideas	Our team came up with a new idea for the marketing campaign. We suggest that Spain would be the best location for the team-building weekend. Our idea is to completely change the logo. Another way is to increase our online profile.

Getting started

	Formal/Semi-formal	Less formal
Opening and welcome	Thank you for inviting me to speak to you today. I'm here to talk about our new product range.	It's great to be here today. I'd like to show you our latest exciting product.
Providing a brief outline of the talk	The talk consists of three main parts. I'd like to start by giving an outline of the talk. I will be focusing on three main areas. These are ...	I'm going to talk about three things. First ... I've split the talk into three sections. First ...
Telling the audience when they can ask questions	I will be happy to answer any questions during the presentation. Please don't hesitate to ask questions at any point. I welcome questions, but could you please keep them to the end of the presentation? There will be an opportunity to ask questions after the presentation.	Feel free to ask questions during the presentation. Just ask questions as we go along. You don't need to wait till the end. Let's keep questions till the end of the presentation. You'll have time at the end of the presentation to ask any questions.

Moving from point to point

Signposting	Let's start by looking at ... Firstly ... Secondly ... And that leads me on to my next point. OK, let's move on. And finally ...
Referring to earlier points	Remember that at the start of the presentation we said that good staff are key to a successful business? As we already mentioned, good customer service is essential.

Features and benefits

Features	Available in various colours. It can be used at home or in the office. An award-winning design. Made from 100 percent recycled materials. Our most popular model.
Benefits	It's strong/lightweight/stylish/modern/practical/easy to clean/reliable/popular. This means that you can use it at home or in the office. This makes it easier to clean.
Specifications	It weighs 2 kilos / 12 grammes. It's 1 metre long and 3 metres wide. It's made from wood/metal/leather/plastic/glass. It has 250 gigabytes of memory.
Giving examples	For example, the new model is faster. For instance, it allows you to work while commuting. Let me give you an example ...
Adding information	In addition ... Also ... Another important point is ...
Emphasising	The most important thing to remember is that ... This is important because ... This is a key point ...

Presenting visual information

Drawing attention to visuals	As you can see from this slide, (the product is small and stylish). Let's move on to the next slide. Let's look at the sales figures shown in this chart. Now, I'd like to show you the results of our research.
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Closing

Summing up	To sum up ...
Closing	We've reached the end of the presentation. We've come to the end of the talk. Let me end by saying ... In conclusion ...
Thanking the audience	Thank you for listening. Thank you for your attention. It's been a pleasure speaking to you today.
Inviting questions	Does anyone have any questions? Are there any questions? I'm happy to answer any questions.